just at the level of state chiefs. Thus, a younger Rajesh Kumar G.V. will replace Arun Kumar as general secretary (organisation) in Karnataka, Mantri Srinivasulu is being sent to rebuild the party in Punjab and Satish Dhond has been moved from Goa to West Bengal. The big news was the elevation of Sunil Bansal as national general secretary after his successful stint in UP. He will now look after three states that will be vital in 2024—West Bengal, Odisha and Telangana. The BJP won 18 seats in Bengal, eight in Odisha and four in Telangana in 2019 (out of a total of 42, 21 and 17 seats respectively). The party has deployed two of its best poll managers, Bansal and Dhond, to build the organisation and poll narrative in Mamata Banerjee's backyard. Bansal, an ABVP import, had played a pivotal role with Amit Shah in realigning caste combinations in UP. He and Dhond will have to keep Bengal unit chief Sukanta Mazumdar and leader of the opposition Suvendu Adhikari in check while also galvanising the party organisation.

The party has also reconstituted two crucial organisational committees nationally—the central election committee and the party parliamentary board. After the 'restructuring', the Modi- Shah-Nadda troika have total control over proceedings. Those dropped from the national panels include former party chief Nitin Gadkari, MP CM Shivraj Chouhan and ex-Rajya Sabha MP and one of the party's few Muslim faces, Shahnawaz Hussain. The new inductees include lightweights like Iqbal Singh Lalpura, Sudha Yadav and Satyanarayan Jatiya. Former Karnataka CM B.S. Yediyurappa (BSY), ex-Assam CM and Union minister Sarbananda Sonowal and Maharashtra deputy CM Devendra Fadnavis also make it to the lists and, more importantly, balance the power games in their states. BSY was being considered for a gubernatorial stint, but the troika felt he could galvanise the influential Lingayat vote in Karnataka. Sonowal is a useful counterbalance for the ambitious chief minister, Himanta Biswa Sarma, in Assam.

The 11 states that vote before 2024 account for 129 Lok Sabha seats, of which the BJP had won 115 in 2019. The party's campaign strategy plays to a script—the activation of the larger Sangh cadre, the role of the *panna samitis* (micro units that monitor names on each page of the voters' list), booth- and block-level *pramukhs* to lure last-mile voters, barnstorming by national leaders etc. The prelude, quite often, in poll-bound states is the sacking of a chief minister who is replaced by a fresh, non-controversial face, presumably to neutralise anti-incumbency. The last such head to roll was of youthful Biplab Deb in Tripura, whose runaway mouth and inability to rein in warring factions did him in. Rajya Sabha MP and state unit chief Manik Saha replaced him.

The move paid off in Uttarakhand when 46-year-old Pushkar Singh Dhami was handed the reins; Basavaraj Bommai in Karnataka (who replaced old warhorse BSY) and Bhupendra Patel in Gujarat (replacing another veteran, Vijay Rupani) are meant to do the same. Himachal CM Jairam Thakur was on the list too—Union minister Anurag Thakur is making a tough bid—but the former seems to have Nadda's backing. Three more CMs are said to be under the troika's scanner.

EXPANDING THE BASE

In the previous round of state polls, the BJP tested its new 'panna samiti' strategy. UP alone had over 9.5 million such committees, claims Nadda, a crucial element for impetus at the grassroots. "There was less noise, more action. The workload was distributed and proved most effective in connecting with voters," he says. Gujarat could have up to 7.5 million panna samitis, and Himachal about 200,000. Alongside, the BJP is mobilising its seven other morchas—mahila, yuva, OBC, SC, ST, minority and farmers—to set up mandal-level teams.

The BJP national executive at Hyderabad in July was used as a springboard for Telangana—national office-bearers were sent out to all 119 assemblies for two days for feedback and it concluded with a massive public meeting addressed by PM Modi. The party is hoping to cream off any anti-incumbency against the K. Chandrashekar Rao-led Telangana Rashtra Samithi government. G. Krishna Reddy being made Union minister is part of the plan. The party also

THE PRACHARAK GENERALS



SUNIL BANSAL
National general secretary

In charge of crucial states like West Bengal, Odisha, Telangana



SAUDAN SINGH
National vice-president

In charge of the Himachal Pradesh polls and also leads party's affairs in Punjab, Chandigarh, Haryana and Uttarakhand



AJAY JAMWAL
Regional general secretary (organisation)

Organisational affairs in Chhattisgarh and MP. Focus on curbing factionalism, nurturing new leaders



SHRI PRAKASH
Joint general secretary

Oversees organisational work in Maharashtra after BJP returned to power with Shiv Sena rebel group



SUNIL DEODHAR
National secretary

Credited for turning around party's fortunes in Tripura; now anchoring BJP expansion in Andhra Pradesh